The Case for Calling Mississippi

By Benjamin Rouan

Mississippi U.S. Senate 2026 · Scott Colom (D) v. Cindy Hyde-Smith (R) v. Ty Pinkins (I) · Figures as of Friday, Nov. 6, 2026, 6:45 PM CST · Prepared for the Associated Press

Thesis: Scott Colom's lead cannot be overcome by the ballots that remain. The race is callable now.

Colom leads by 2,574 votes on AP's count,[24] and by 2,821 once county-published batches that AP has not yet loaded are included (Section 1).[21,22,23,25] AP's own expected-vote figures put about 30,300 votes still out.[24] For Hyde-Smith to win, those votes would have to break 54% her way (Section 5). Four independent lines of evidence say they will not, and most say they will do the opposite:

1. **AP's own remainder favors Colom.** Apply each county's current vote share to AP's county-by-county estimate of what is left, with no adjustment for ballot type. The remaining vote nets Colom roughly **+3,300** (Section 2).[24] Remove most of Hinds County's remainder, as the county's records suggest,[3,4,7] and it still nets Colom about **+900**.
2. **Affidavit ballots are breaking for Colom everywhere.** Fifteen counties have added post-election batches (Section 3).[13,14,15,16,21,23,24,25] In every one, Colom beat his own share of that county's vote, by 4 to 30 points. The ten confirmed affidavit batches split 65%–35% for Colom. That includes counties Trump carried by 50 points.[16]
3. **Late mail is too small to matter.** About 2,850 mail ballots are still outstanding statewide (Secretary of State, Nov. 6).[1] Historically, only a small fraction arrive in the five-day window: Hinds counted 18 late mail ballots against 1,093 unreturned in 2024.[4,27] Even if a quarter of them arrived, more than ten times that rate, and every one went to Hyde-Smith, she would net about 700 votes, roughly a quarter of the lead (Section 4).
4. **Hinds County can only widen the margin.** AP shows Hinds at 93% reporting, about 5,800 votes out, in a county Colom leads 80%–19%.[24] The county's precinct data indicate its absentees were already counted,[3,4] and the commissioners' own district counts put the true remainder at roughly 1,500–2,500, nearly all affidavits.[7] If AP's figure is right instead, Colom's final margin grows to about 1.1–1.2 points (Section 6f). Either way, the uncertainty in Hinds is only about how large Colom's win is.

A simulation of every outstanding pool, county by county (Section 5), gives Colom better than a 99.9% chance of winning. Even with affidavit lean set to zero, so that every remaining ballot votes exactly like its county, he wins in 99.7% of runs. Hyde-Smith wins only if remaining

affidavit voters are substantially *more Republican* than their own counties, the reverse of every batch reported so far (Section 5).

1. Where the count stands

Source	Colom	Hyde-Smith	Pinkins	Total	Colom lead
AP	467,930	465,356	20,028	953,314	+2,574 (+0.27 pt)
Decision Desk HQ	468,339	465,643	20,043	954,025	+2,696 (+0.28 pt)
Most complete count (see below)	**468,485**	**465,664**	**20,044**	**954,193**	**+2,821 (+0.30 pt)**

AP results feed[24] and Decision Desk HQ results feed,[25] read 6:45 PM CST Nov. 6.

The most complete count

The two feeds load county batches at different times. The "most complete" row takes, for each of the 82 counties, whichever of AP, DDHQ or the county's own published figures reports the most ballots. It differs from AP in five counties:

County	Figure used	Colom	Hyde-Smith	Pinkins	AP shows	Net v. AP	Source
Lowndes	DDHQ, confirmed by county records	12,553	9,006	243	12,211 / 8,834 / 239	C +170	Note a[21,25]
Chickasaw	DDHQ; MFP county report	3,462	2,894	87	3,381 / 2,871 / 86	C +58	Note b[16,25]
Washington	County election commission	8,722	2,382	163	8,660 / 2,369 / 162	C +49	Note c[22]
Tippah	DDHQ; county affidavit tally	1,862	5,409	171	1,823 / 5,378 / 171	C +8	Note d[23,25]
George	DDHQ	1,138	5,475	256	1,107 / 5,406 / 246	H +38	Note e[25]
Net difference v. AP						**C +247**	

- **a. Lowndes:** DDHQ feed, batches of Nov. 4–5 and Nov. 6, 4:23 PM CST.[25] The combined affidavit total (Colom 342, Hyde-Smith 172, Pinkins 4) matches the county's affidavit records shown on video by Abiola Agoro, who obtained them in person (X, Nov. 6, 4:05 PM CST).[21] The county reported "more than 550" affidavits cast (Deputy Circuit Clerk Ann Marie Higgins, Commercial Dispatch, Nov. 4).[21]

- **b. Chickasaw:** Mississippi Free Press, Nov. 6, 12:40 PM CST: 204 affidavits cast, 105 accepted, Colom 81, Hyde-Smith 23, Pinkins 1.[16] DDHQ loaded the same batch at 4:01 PM CST.[25]
- **c. Washington:** Delta Democrat-Times, Nov. 4, 10:10 AM CST, "unofficial results from the Washington County Election Commission," all 19 precincts.[22] Neither feed has loaded the commission's figures.
- **d. Tippah:** county affidavit tally, 147 cast, 71 accepted, Colom 39, Hyde-Smith 31.[23] DDHQ loaded the batch Nov. 6; AP has not.[25]
- **e. George:** DDHQ feed, Nov. 6, 6:41 PM CST; unlabelled batch of 110 (Colom 31, Hyde-Smith 69, Pinkins 10).[25]

Every other county matches AP exactly, or AP already carries the larger figure. Where AP and DDHQ differed earlier today on Oktibbeha, Pike, Marion, Benton, Scott, Holmes, Wilkinson and Choctaw, both have now loaded the same batches.

2. AP's own remainder, at today's county leans

AP's expected-vote parameters total 983,599, so about 30,285 remain.[24] The table applies each county's current two-party share to AP's remaining votes for that county. This assumes nothing about affidavits: it treats every remaining ballot as if it votes like the county already has. County shares are from the AP feed.[24]

County	AP votes remaining	Colom share of county vote	Net at county lean
Hinds	5,831	80.8%	Colom +3,545
Lee	2,777	41.0%	Hyde-Smith +488
Rankin	2,195	36.9%	Hyde-Smith +562
DeSoto	2,140	53.1%	Colom +131
Madison	2,042	50.4%	Colom +16
Harrison	2,008	48.1%	Hyde-Smith +74
Jackson	1,551	42.5%	Hyde-Smith +227
All other counties	11,741	—	Colom +930
Statewide	**30,285**		**Colom +3,271**
Same, with Hinds remainder cut to 2,000	26,454		Colom +942

Under AP's own figures, the remaining vote widens Colom's lead by about 3,300 before any affidavit effect. The Hyde-Smith-leaning remainders (Lee, Rankin, Jackson, Harrison) net her

about 1,350 in total, far short of the 2,574 she needs, and that is before Hinds, DeSoto and Madison add to Colom's side.

3. Affidavit ballots are breaking for Colom, including in Republican counties

Most of what remains is affidavit (provisional) ballots. The Secretary of State reported 11,202 processed statewide by Friday afternoon, 8,717 accepted (78%) and 2,485 rejected,[1] up from 6,936 processed Thursday night.[2] For every county that has added affidavits, the table compares Colom's share of the county's regular vote with his share of its affidavits.

County	Colom	Hyde-Smith	Pinkins	Colom share, county vote	Colom share, affidavits	Difference	Net	Source
Oktibbeha	401	96	5	60.7%	80.7%	+20.0	C +305	County PDF[13]
Lowndes	342	172	4	58.0%	66.5%	+8.5	C +170	DDHQ; county documents[21,25]
Pike	159	59	2	58.7%	72.9%	+14.2	C +100	County PDF[14]
Lafayette	142	60	5	50.4%	70.3%	+19.9	C +82	County PDF; MFP[15]
Chickasaw	81	23	1	54.1%	77.9%	+23.8	C +58	MFP[16]
Marion	67	47	3	39.0%	58.8%	+19.8	C +20	County tally; on AP and DDHQ[24,25]
Tippah	39	31	0	25.3%	55.7%	+30.4	C +8	County tally; on DDHQ[23,25]
Benton	17	12	3	45.7%	58.6%	+12.9	C +5	AP; MFP count[16]
Alcorn	44	75	5	23.0%	37.0%	+14.0	H +31	MFP[16]
Itawamba	53	151	9	15.8%	26.0%	+10.2	H +98	MFP[16]

County	Colom	Hyde-Smith	Pinkins	Colom share, county vote	Colom share, affidavits	Difference	Net	Source
10 confirmed batches	**1,345**	**726**	**37**		**64.9%**		**C +619**	
Wilkinson*	107	33	1	70.1%	76.4%	+6.3	C +74	AP/DDHQ batch[24,25]
Holmes*	84	8	0	86.8%	91.3%	+4.5	C +76	AP batch[24]
Scott*	85	26	2	48.9%	76.6%	+27.7	C +59	AP/DDHQ batch[24,25]
George*	31	69	10	17.2%	31.0%	+13.8	H +38	DDHQ batch[25]
Choctaw*	20	21	1	34.3%	48.8%	+14.5	H +1	AP/DDHQ batch[24,25]

"Colom share" is his share of the two-party vote. The county figure excludes the batch itself and comes from the AP and DDHQ feeds.[24,25] *Post-election batches the county has not labelled; their size and lean match affidavits. All 15 batches run more Colom than their county. None runs toward Hyde-Smith.

Hyde-Smith netted votes only in Alcorn, Itawamba and George, counties Trump carried by 50 to 65 points in 2024,[28] and even there by less than her overall margin. The Mississippi Free Press noted that across Alcorn, Chickasaw and Itawamba she netted just 71 votes "despite holding substantial overall leads in two of those counties."[16]

The pattern has a known cause. Mississippi moved more than 200,000 voters to inactive status before the election and requires inactive voters to vote by affidavit.[19,26] A DeSoto County commissioner said "more than half" of the affidavits she reviewed were from previously inactive voters who were reactivated and whose ballots will count.[11] Those voters are not a random sample of their county.

4. Late mail cannot close the gap

- **How many:** just under 2,900 mail ballots (2,857) were still outstanding Friday afternoon,[1] down from about 3,300 Thursday night. These are ballots sent out and not returned. Those postmarked by Election Day can arrive through 5 PM Tuesday, Nov. 10.

- **How many will arrive:** few. Hinds' certified 2024 results show 18 "5 Day Absentee" ballots[4] against 1,093 unreturned on the Secretary of State's Nov. 4, 2024 absentee report,[27] under 2%. Even at ten times that rate, late mail adds a few hundred votes statewide.
- **Where they are:** the Secretary of State has not published a county breakdown of the 2,857. Its last county-level report, from Nov. 2, showed 6,587 unreturned ballots, 43% of them in counties Hyde-Smith leads and 57% in counties Colom leads.[8] If the remaining ballots are spread the same way and split at county leans (AP feed),[24] all 2,857 arriving would net Colom about +300.
- **The ceiling, with no assumption about where they are:** if a quarter of the 2,857 arrived, more than ten times the 2024 Hinds rate, and every one of them voted for Hyde-Smith, she would net about 714 votes,[1] roughly a quarter of the 2,574-vote lead.

5. Hyde-Smith's path, tested

With about 30,300 votes left[24] and Pinkins taking about 2%, Hyde-Smith needs **54.3% of the two-party remainder**. In the affidavit batches so far (Section 3) she has won 35%. She has exceeded 54% only in Alcorn (63%), Itawamba (74%) and George (69%), three small counties that together hold under 500 of the remaining votes.[24]

What would have to be true for Hyde-Smith to win

The table comes from a county-by-county simulation (200,000 draws) of every outstanding pool: each county's measured or estimated affidavit count, acceptance rates centred on the measured county and Secretary of State figures,[1,10,16,20] late mail,[1,8] and named uncounted blocks such as Hancock's and Monroe's outstanding absentees.[29] Each row changes one thing: how the remaining affidavits lean compared with their own county. The last column says whether any of the 15 reported batches (Section 3) has behaved that way.

If the remaining affidavits…	Colom wins	Final margin, median (10–90%)	Seen in any county so far?
…lean toward Colom as the reported batches have (about 10–20 points more than their county)	>99.9%	+0.86 (+0.68 to +1.08)	Yes, in 15 of 15 batches
…have no lean at all, and vote exactly like each county's counted vote	**99.7%**	+0.36 (+0.20 to +0.55)	No. Every batch leaned more to Colom than its county, by 4 to 30 points
…have no lean, and acceptance runs high (about 79%)	99.5%	+0.38 (+0.19 to +0.59)	No, same as above

If the remaining affidavits…	Colom wins	Final margin, median (10–90%)	Seen in any county so far?
…lean about 12 points *toward Hyde-Smith* compared with their own county, in every county, with high acceptance	42%	−0.03 (−0.22 to +0.17)	**No. This is the reverse of every batch reported.** It is shown only to mark where her path would begin.

Read the last row as a boundary, not a scenario. To reach even odds, Hyde-Smith needs affidavit voters statewide to be markedly more Republican than the counties they live in. Fifteen counties have reported, across every region of the state and every partisan lean, and all fifteen went the other way. The conservative case is the second row, no affidavit lean at all, and it is not close.

6. Hinds County: AP's 7% outstanding is very likely too high, and it does not matter for the call

AP shows Hinds at 93% reporting: 77,465 counted against 83,296 expected, so about 5,800 out. AP's expected-vote parameters for Hinds are 74,951 Election Day in-person, 8,083 advance or absentee, and only 262 provisional.[24] In other words, AP's remainder assumes thousands of *regular* ballots are still uncounted, and almost no affidavits. The county's records point the other way on both.

a. The precinct data show absentees are already counted

Hinds' 2024 certified precinct report splits every precinct into Election Day and absentee votes.[4] Absentee shares ranged from 1.6% to 31.5%. If 2026 absentees were missing from the election-night report,[3] precincts heavy with absentee voters would look badly short against 2024. They do not:

2024 absentee share of precinct	Precincts	2024 total	2026 counted	2026 as % of 2024	Expected if absentees missing
1.6–7.7%	22	7,013	6,099	87%	98%
7.7–10.0%	21	13,113	11,955	91%	94%
10.0–11.9%	21	15,584	13,344	86%	92%
11.9–15.1%	21	16,736	14,962	89%	89%
15.1–31.5%	22	34,457	30,460	88%	82%

Turnout relative to 2024 is flat at 86–91% in every group. That is what counted absentees look like. Missing absentees would show as a steady decline down the table. Raymond 1, the most absentee-heavy precinct (31.5% in 2024), stands at 81% of its 2024 turnout; for its absentees to be uncounted, its 2026 Election Day turnout would have to exceed the 2024 presidential

election by 18%. A regression across all 107 matched precincts, controlling for partisanship, puts the share of 2026 absentees already counted at 100% (90% interval 84–123%).

b. State rule: absentee scanning starts the moment polls close

> *"After the close of the polls at 7:00 p.m., the Resolution Board will open the ballot box containing the accepted absentee ballots ... and shall immediately begin processing the accepted ballots through the central scanner. ... The totals shall then be combined with the precinct tabulation totals for the unofficial vote count."*

Mississippi Administrative Code, Secretary of State Rule 731c, Part 17 Rule 3.2 (e)–(f).[5] Envelope review may begin when the polls open (3.2(a)). The rule also lets the board "recess as necessary and resume" before certification (3.2(g)), so it sets the expected practice rather than compelling it. The precinct data are the evidence that Hinds followed it this year.

c. The county described its post-election work as late mail and unreadable ballots

> *"The Hinds County Resolution Board began reviewing and processing absentee ballots at noon Nov. 4. That process includes eligible mail-in ballots received after Election Day, as well as ballots that cannot be properly read by scanning equipment."*

WLBT, Nov. 4, 2026, reporting the Hinds County Election Commission's statement through board attorney Tony Gaylor.[6] Hinds had 8,070 absentees returned by Nov. 2 and 639 not returned;[8] mail "received after Election Day" can only come from the latter.

d. What is actually left in Hinds

Affidavits, which the county has not yet released. Commissioners have given counts for three of five districts: about 650 in District 5, 387 in District 3, and 136 from 5 of District 4's 14 precincts.[7] Scaled to all five districts, that is roughly 2,300 cast. District 1 Commissioner Kidada Brown has said the county will not "turn a number in until everyone is complete."[7] At the acceptance rates seen elsewhere, Hinds' affidavits yield about 1,300–1,800 votes. With a few hundred late mail ballots, the realistic remainder is 1,500–2,500, not 5,800. It is also far more than the 262 provisionals in AP's Hinds parameters.

e. Why the higher estimate is understandable

- **2023 precedent.** On election night in the 2023 governor's race, Hinds reported only 447 absentees and counted the rest the next day.[17] A model trained on that behavior would expect the same in 2026. The 2026 election-night report uses a different template with no vote-type columns, and the precinct test above shows the absentees are in.
- **The "exceeded 2020" statement.** The commission said preliminary figures indicated participation exceeded the November 2020 presidential election.[6] Hinds cast 100,944 ballots in 2020.[30] Even adding every absentee and affidavit to the current 77,465 would not reach that. The statement cannot be literal and should not be read as evidence of a large uncounted pool.

- **Turnout against the rest of the state.** Statewide, the 2026 count stands at 77.6% of the 2024 presidential vote.[24,28] Hinds is at 89.2%, right at the median for comparable Black-majority counties. Another 9,000 votes would put Hinds at 99.6% of its presidential-year turnout, the highest of all 82 counties.

f. Either way, Hinds helps only Colom

If AP's 5,800 were right[24] and split like the rest of Hinds (Colom 80–19), Colom's final margin would rise to roughly **+1.10 to +1.18 points**. If the county's own data are right, Hinds adds about 1,000–1,500 net for Colom. Neither scenario offers Hyde-Smith anything. A model that keeps the race uncalled because 7% of Hinds is outstanding is holding the call on votes that can only extend the leader's margin.

7. What comes next

Date (CST)	Event
Through the weekend	Rankin commissioners continue verifying affidavits; about half done, about 20% rejected so far[10]
Tue Nov. 10, 10 AM	Harrison County commission decides which of its 1,448 affidavits to accept[9]
Tue Nov. 10, 5 PM	Deadline for postmarked mail and ID cures. Rankin begins scanning affidavits[10]
Wed Nov. 11, 3 PM	DeSoto County holds its public review and count of about 2,100 affidavits[11]
Fri Nov. 13	County certification deadline[18]

What is uncertain, stated plainly

- **Acceptance rates vary.** Chickasaw 51%, Tippah 48%, Itawamba 66%, Rankin about 80% so far, Lowndes about 90%.[10,16] The large Republican-leaning pools (Rankin, Harrison, Jackson) have not finished. Lower acceptance shrinks both candidates' gains; it does not change direction.
- **The statewide affidavit total is not known.** Published estimates run from 12,000 to 20,000-plus.[19] Counted county figures already total about 15,800 in counties holding half the state's vote.[7,9,10,11,12,13,16,21] A larger pool helps Colom at the leans observed; a smaller pool leaves Hyde-Smith fewer votes to recover with.
- **Five of the 15 batches are unlabelled** (marked *). The ten confirmed batches tell the same story.
- **Cures.** Wrong-precinct affidavits cannot be cured.[10] Photo-ID affidavits and some voters registered through the Department of Public Safety can be. Cures can only raise acceptance, and the ID group is small: 365 of 21,421 affidavits in 2024.[20]

- **Hinds' election-night practice in 2024 could not be checked** (no archived copy). The 2026 conclusion rests on the 2026 precinct data, the county's own description of its work, and the state rule.

Sources and documents

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5. Mississippi Secretary of State, Administrative Code Rule 731c, Part 17 (absentee processing, Rules 3.1–3.2). sos.ms.gov/adminsearch/ACCode/00000731c.pdf
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12. Mississippi Free Press, "Jackson County Received More Than 1,400 Affidavit Ballots," Nov. 5, 2026. mississippifreepress.org

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15. Mississippi Free Press, "Lafayette County's Affidavit Ballots Break for Scott Colom 69%-29%." mississippifreepress.org

16. Mississippi Free Press, "Scott Colom Is Overperforming Affidavit Ballots in North Mississippi—Even in Hyde-Smith Friendly Counties," Nov. 6, 2026 (Alcorn, Chickasaw, Itawamba, Benton, Tishomingo, Calhoun, Pontotoc). mississippifreepress.org

17. Hinds County 2023 election-night unofficial results (archived Nov. 9, 2023; Election Day 64,232, absentee 447). web.archive.org

18. Mississippi Free Press, "Mississippi Counties Have a Hard Deadline to Certify Election Results." mississippifreepress.org

19. NPR, "No one knows how many ballots are outstanding in Mississippi's Senate race," Nov. 6, 2026 (inactive-voter rule; estimates of the affidavit pool). npr.org. Magnolia Tribune, "Thousands of affidavit ballots could decide Mississippi Senate race," Nov. 6, 2026. magnoliatribune.com

20. U.S. Election Assistance Commission, Election Administration and Voting Survey 2020–2024 (Mississippi provisional ballots by county and reason: 2024 cast 21,421, counted 14,685; 365 cast for lack of ID). eac.gov

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30. Hinds County, November 3, 2020 General Election Official Summary Report (100,944 ballots cast). co.hinds.ms.us/pgs/elections/20201124_Official Summary Report.pdf

Counts are from the AP and Decision Desk HQ results feeds, read at 6:45 PM CST Nov. 6, 2026. AP's remaining-vote figures are its published expected-vote parameters by county. The precinct comparison uses the Hinds County 2026 unofficial precinct report and 2024 certified precinct report (107 of 108 precincts matched; one precinct's line is unreadable in the county's PDF). The simulation draws affidavit counts, acceptance and lean per county with statewide shared shifts; its assumptions are stated in each table.